

provided by popular sites such as Twitter and identi.ca:

- follow – Anyone can follow any user. Users who are being followed can control whether or not someone can follow them.
- tweet – To tweet is to post a small text message of 140 characters or less in your account, which is usually related to what's happening in your life. Many companies and individuals also tweet to market or advertise products, or simply share updates.
- timeline – This refers to a user's tweets.
- Re-tweet – This is all about spreading the word. Just as you forward an interesting email to your friends, you can re-tweet someone else's tweet so that your followers also get the update.
- direct messages (DM) – This is like sending a private message to someone and only works if the person is following you.
- URL shortener – URLs are generally long. And since tweets can't be longer than 140 characters, you don't want to waste character space by sharing a long URL. This is where URL shortening services like tinyurl.com, bit.ly, is.gd, etc, come handy. With their help you can convert a 50-character URL to less than 10 characters.

With all that jargon from twitter-land out of our way, let's start exploring the various clients available for tweeting from our desktops in a GNU/Linux system. Ranging from raw APIs to impressive-looking GUI, there are plenty of clients available for tweeting. In fact, if you are a Python developer, it won't take much time to roll out your own twitter client!

Gwibber

Developed using Python and GTK+, Gwibber targets GNOME users. The initial development was started by the Ubuntu community, but over time, it's been available on most distros. It supports a number of services such as Twitter, identi.ca, Laconica, FriendFeed, Facebook, Jaiku, Digg, Flickr, Brightkite, Qaiku and even has experimental support for OpenCollaboration. Naturally, it supports multiple-account configuration with these different services, simultaneously.

The setting up of accounts is straightforward. The user interface looks similar to an e-mail client in some senses, where different accounts and the related items are grouped together. The menus are simple enough and self-explanatory. And the best part is that almost everything you want from a microblogging client is available.

You can differentiate tweets from different microblogging services by assigning colours to each service, as you can see in Figure 1. Here, all tweets from Twitter have a light blue colour strip, and those from identi.ca have a light green strip. This is very handy when using multiple accounts from different microblogging service providers.

Just like your IM client, you can choose whether to minimise to tray or close Gwibber, on clicking the X. It also shows notification bubbles when new tweets arrive. Another good feature is the URL shortener support, which is still experimental at the time of this writing. Some URL shortener services you can



Figure 1: Gwibber is the first choice for GNOME users

choose from are cli.gs, is.gd, tinyurl.com, tr.im and url.com.

Re-tweeting and replying is a piece of cake. In fact, tweeting/re-tweeting an update to multiple accounts is also possible. Besides, it gives you fine grained control when choosing the time interval (in minutes) for auto-refreshing the timelines—either by typing the value or by sliding through the combo box. What else? The search interface helps you search for tweets.

Finally, support for themes means you can choose from a range of available themes or write one on your own to fit your desktop's look and feel.

Twitux

Twitux is another GTK+ based Twitter client that targets GNOME users. It has a very simple user interface that displays the timelines of those you follow. The best part is that it's very easy to use.

There is a way to filter the timelines. Some of the different timeline views available are *public*, *friends*, *my*, *twitux*, *direct messages*, *direct replies*, etc. Apart from these generic timeline views, it also has a menu item called 'Friends' in which all the users whom you follow are listed, which provides a way to filter and view an individual's timeline.

GNOME integration is quite decent—the GNOME notifier updates you on new tweets, and GNOME Keyring manages authentication credentials. Other features available in twitux are:

- Expanding messages
- Switching between showing the user name and real name
- Retrieval intervals can be configured (3, 5, 15, 30, 60 minutes)
- The manual refresh of tweets
- A spell checker for your tweets
- Adding friends
- Sending direct messages
- Storing credentials and connecting automatically
- Sound notifications when a message is received



Figure 2: Twitux has a basic UI